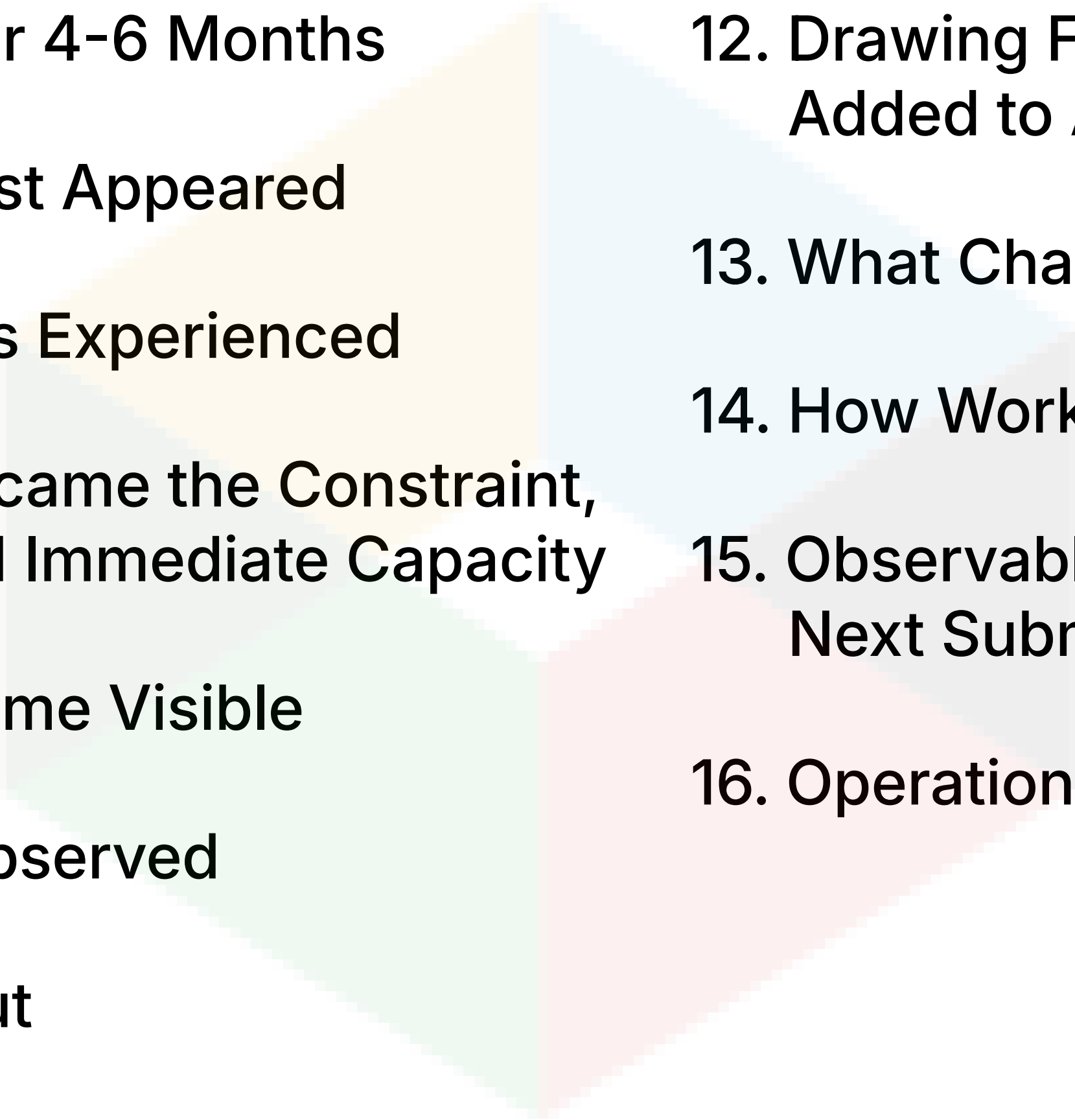




How Mid-Size Firms

Stabilize Documentation

During Growth spurts



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Firm Snapshot

FIRM TYPE: Mid-size architecture firm

PROJECT TYPE: Commercial and mixed-use projects

PROJECT SCOPE: Simultaneous Design Development (DD) and Construction Documentation (CD) phases

KEY CHALLENGE: Senior architects leading drawing reviews

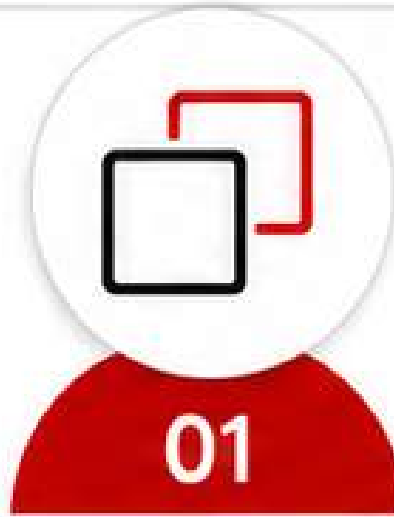
Mid-size architecture firms often reach a stage where winning projects is no longer the problem, but delivering them consistently becomes the real challenge.

In this case, a 51–200 person architecture firm experienced a rapid increase in active project across commercial and mixed-use developments. Within a few months, their production environment shifted from steady delivery to overlapping documentation cycles across multiple projects.

DD and CD phases, which were previously staggered and manageable, began running in parallel across several active jobs. Senior architects found themselves reviewing more drawings than planning design direction, and submission cycles started stacking on top of each other.

What Changed Over 4-6 Months

The firm entered a high-growth period where project delivery conditions shifted rapidly:



01

Overlapping Starts:

New project initiations began to stack rather than sequence.



02

Production Volume:

A higher volume of DD and CD drawing packages entered production simultaneously.



03

Deadline Alignment:

Issue-for-review and issue-for-construction deadlines aligned across multiple projects.



04

Submission Cycles:

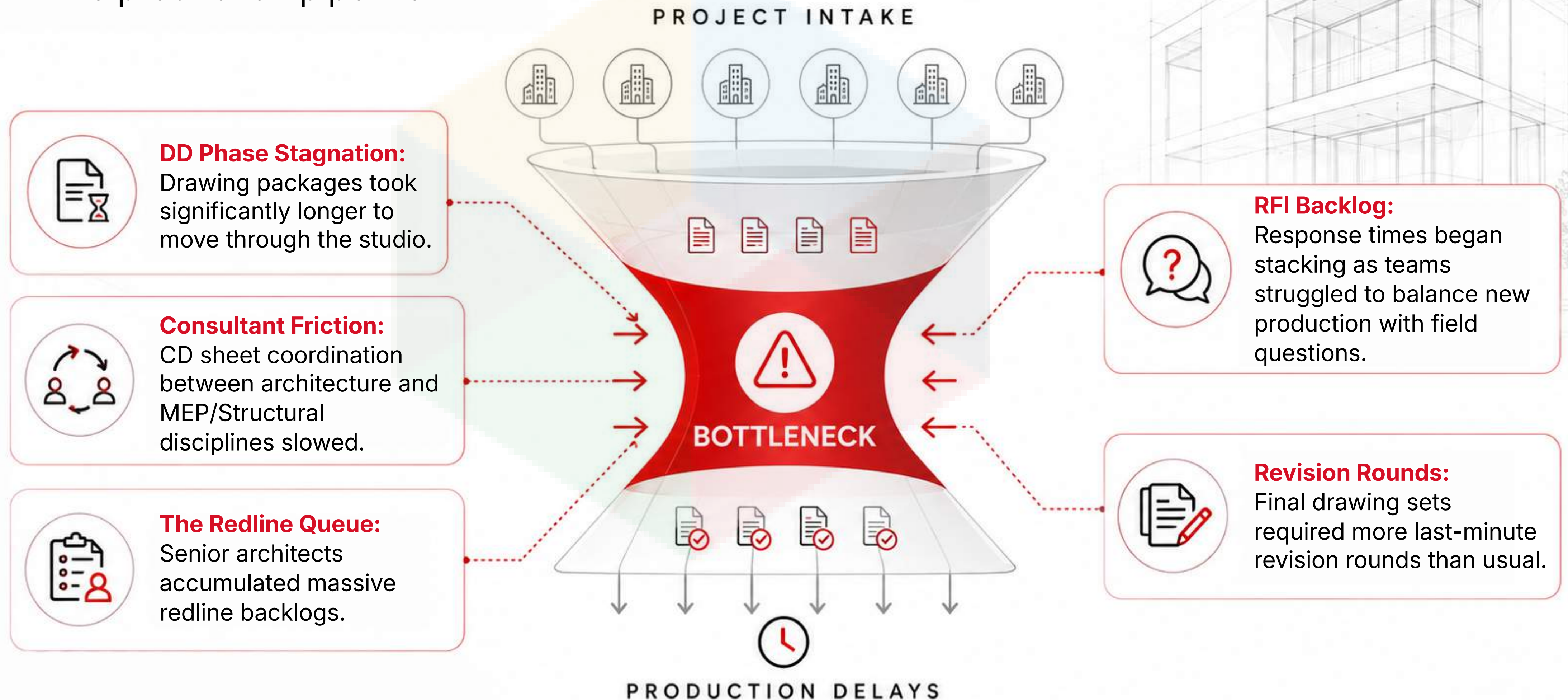
Project teams were forced to manage multiple active submission cycles at the same time.



What had changed wasn't the complexity of design;
it was the simultaneous load on documentation production.

Where Pressure First Appeared

The internal strain showed up as a technical bottleneck in the production pipeline



Scope of Project

Inside project teams, the impact became visible in workflow friction.

The organization was still delivering, but predictability was weakening.



Approvals took longer than planned



Submission buffers started shrinking



Late-stage revisions became routine



Coordination meetings increased before every issue date



Teams worked extended hours closer to deadlines



Project Starts Increased



Drawing Backlog Formed



Submission Pressure Increased



At this stage, it was not design complexity that created delays. It was the accumulation of drawing production load across overlapping projects.

CD Deliverables Became the Constraint, Leadership Needed Immediate Capacity

With increased overlapping projects, Construction Documentation (CD) became the most sensitive point in the delivery chain.

It wasn't that work stopped moving; instead, it stopped moving smoothly.

Where Delays Became Visible

- As the bottleneck tightened, the impact on project health became undeniable.
- Construction drawing packages began missing internal issue targets.
- Sheet coordination cycles between the firm and consultants were extended, risking errors.
- Redlines were being generated faster than the current team could clear them.
- Submission readiness required intensive, manual intervention from leadership.

What Leadership Observed

From a leadership perspective, the shift was subtle but concerning.



Senior architects were spending disproportionate time on drawing corrections instead of guiding coordination.



Project managers were tracking drawing status more than managing design intent.



Submission readiness became something that needed active intervention rather than a predictable outcome.

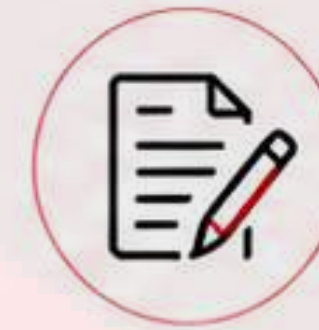


Across projects, delivery timelines became harder to forecast with confidence.



What Was Ruled Out

A root-cause analysis confirmed the delays were not caused by:



Design revisions or client approvals.



Software, BIM tools, or technical infrastructure.



The fundamental capability of the internal team.



What Was Identified



The Constraint:
Insufficient drawing production capacity during overlapping DD and CD phases.



The firm wasn't short on talent; it was short on **usable production bandwidth during peak overlap.**



Decision Conditions

Leadership needed a solution that could:



Stabilize drawing flow immediately.



Maintain the firm's strict quality and BIM standards.



Avoid delaying any active project submissions.



Add capacity without the 3-6 month lag of traditional onboarding.



Options Considered



Hiring additional architects



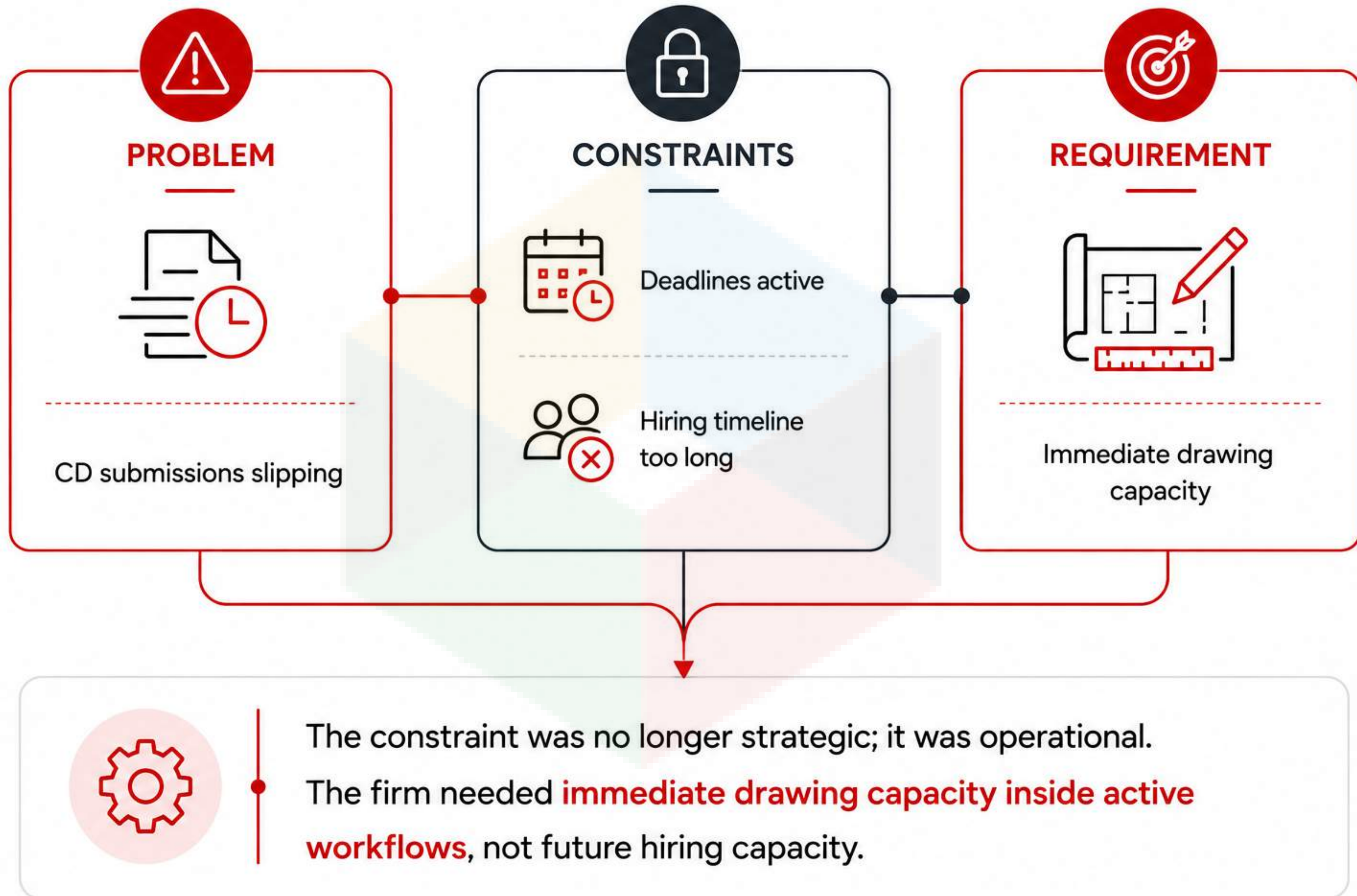
Redistributing drawing work internally



Using freelancers for drafting support



Adding dedicated drawing production capacity



Drawing Flow Stabilized After Capacity Was Added to Active Projects

Instead of restructuring teams or changing design processes, the firm introduced additional drawing production support directly into active CD workflows.

The goal was not to replace internal teams, but to absorb overflow where the pressure was building.

What Changed in the Workflow

The firm integrated dedicated support specifically for active CD drawing production



The firm integrated
dedicated support
specifically for active
CD drawing production



Targeted Assignment:
Work was assigned
to specific, high-volume
submission packages.



Structured Cycles:
Redline resolution
followed a disciplined
review-and-return cycle.



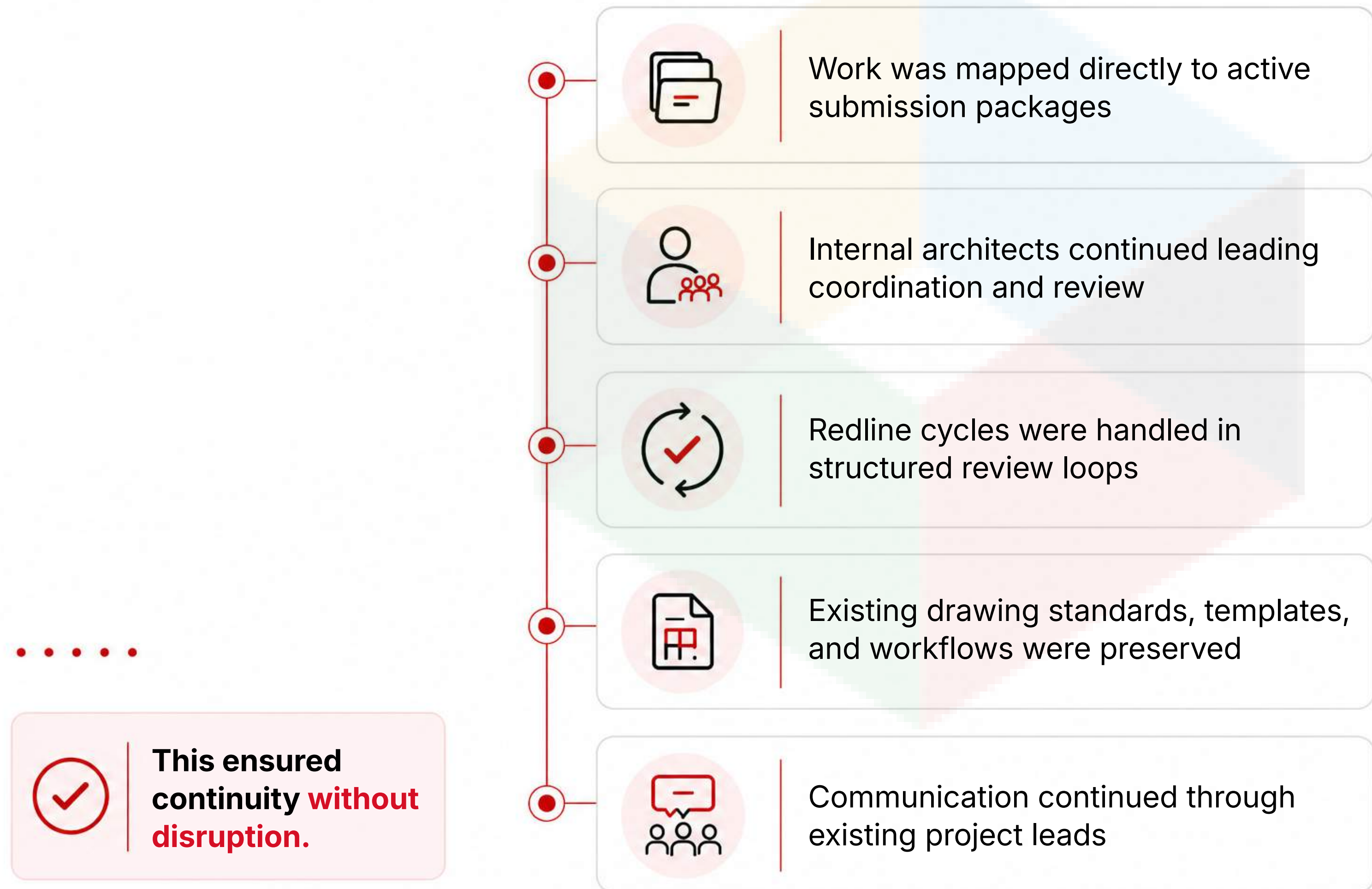
Consistent Oversight:
Coordination remained
led by the firm's internal
project architects.



Standardized Output:
Drawing standards and
Revit templates remained
completely unchanged.

How Work Was Integrated

Support was embedded into ongoing projects rather than treated as a separate layer:





Observable Changes Within the Next Submission Cycle

The impact was visible quickly in the project delivery workflow.



Timely Completion

CD drawing sets were completed on schedule.



Queue Management

Senior redline queues were reduced to manageable levels.



Improved Metrics

RFI response times improved and submission readiness became predictable.



Cultural Shift

Late-night revision cycles decreased significantly.



Operational Impact on the Team

The operational shift changed how teams functioned day to day.



Senior Focus

Architects returned to high-value coordination and planning.



Visibility

Project managers regained clear visibility into the production schedule.



Confidence

Teams worked with clearer timelines and less "submission anxiety."



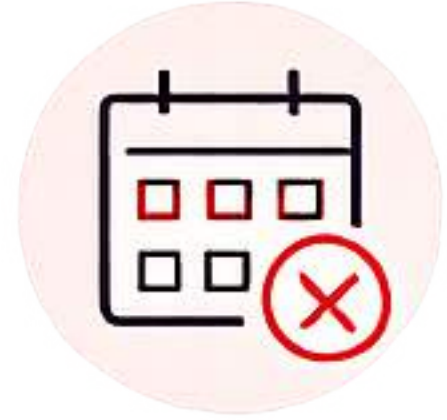
Consistency

Drawing quality remained high across all active projects.

BEFORE



Stacked redlines



Delayed submissions



Unpredictable
issue dates

VS

AFTER



Cleared review queues



On time submissions



Predictable
issue cycles



The most important change was not speed; it was stability.

Architectural drawing production aligned with project demand.
restoring predictability across active delivery cycles without increasing senior team size.



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